

Methods of Deleting and Correcting Mistakes in Ancient Egyptian Religious Manuscripts

Methods of Deleting and Correcting Mistakes in Ancient Egyptian Religious Manuscripts

طرق حذف وتصحيح الأخطاء في المخطوطات الدينية المصرية القديمة

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Abstract

Ancient Egyptian scribes made some mistakes while writing texts. Sometimes, the mistakes were not corrected, but in other cases, the texts were reviewed, and the mistakes were corrected. By collecting most of the models in which methods of deleting and correcting mistakes were included, a complete idea can be formed. Therefore, this study examines the methods used by the scribes or reviewers to delete and correct the mistakes, focusing on the *Book of the Dead*, whether in hieratic or cursive hieroglyphic script. The study showed that some corrections were incomplete when the scribes deleted the wrong part without replacing it. We also notice the similarity of mistakes and correcting methods in certain texts, such as the *Book of the Dead*, whether written on papyrus or mummy bandages. The correcting mistakes methods were defined based on the time of discovering the mistakes, either during writing or revision. The scribes erased mistakes and made corrections while writing, sometimes by changing the shape of incorrect signs to correct signs. In the Ptolemaic period, new methods were adopted to delete incorrect words without distorting the text, such as writing the correct word after the incorrect word without deleting the incorrect one, placing a circular line, dots in red ink or brackets around the incorrect word.

Keywords: Correction, mistakes, deletion, hieratic, cursive hieroglyphic, the book of the dead

الملخص

ارتكب الكتبة المصريون القدماء بعض الأخطاء أثناء كتابة النصوص، وفي بعض الأحيان، لم تُصحَّح تلك الأخطاء، بينما في أحيانٍ أخرى خضعت النصوص للمراجعة وتم تصحيحها. ومن خلال تجميع النماذج التي ورد بها أساليب حذف وتصحيح الأخطاء، يمكن تكوين صورة شبه كاملة عن كل الأساليب التي استخدمت لتصحيح النصوص. من ثم، تتناول هذه الدراسة الأساليب التي استخدمها الكتبة لحذف الأخطاء التي وقعوا فيها أثناء كتابة النصوص وكيفية تصحيحها، مع التركيز على نصوص كتاب الموتى، سواء المكتوبة بالخط الهيراطيقي أو الهيروغليفي المختصر. وأظهرت الدراسة أن هناك نوع من التصحيح غير المكتمل عندما قام الكاتب بحذف الجزء الخاطئ دون استبداله، كما نلاحظ تشابه الأخطاء وطرق تصحيحها في نصوص معينة كنصوص كتاب الموتى سواء المكتوبة على البردي أو أربطة الموميאות. وقد اختلفت طريقة تصحيح الأخطاء بناءً على توقيت اكتشاف الخطأ إما أثناء الكتابة أو أثناء المراجعة بعد الانتهاء من كتابة النص. فقام الكتبة بشطب أو محو الأخطاء أثناء الكتابة وكتابة التصحيح، كما استخدم أحياناً أسلوب تحوير وتغيير شكل العلامات الخاطئة للعلامات الصحيحة. وفي العصر البطلمي، تم اعتماد أساليب جديدة لحذف الكلمات الخاطئة دون تشويه النص، مثل كتابة الكلمة الصحيحة بعد الكلمة الخاطئة دون حذف الخاطئة، أو وضع خط دائري، أو نقاط بالحبر الأحمر، أو أقواس حول الكلمة الخاطئة.

الكلمات المفتاحية: تصحيح، أخطاء، حذف، هيراطيقي، هيروغليفي مختصر، كتاب الموتى

Introduction

Some mistakes usually occurred in ancient Egyptian texts when writing or copying texts on various materials.¹ If the scribe corrected mistakes directly during copying, these mistakes were difficult to detect, as he completely wiped away the ink and rewrote the mistaken part. Therefore, the corrections in their various styles were most likely a result of a text review after it was completed.²

There are two possibilities about the person who reviewed and corrected the manuscript: He was the copyist of the text himself; in this case, the corrections and additions above the lines and in the margins were made by the same hand as the main text,³ or he would most likely be a text reviewer if the corrections were made by a different hand.⁴

The term "correction" in ancient Egyptian manuscripts included deleting the extra or repeated part, deleting the mistake without replacing it, deleting the mistake and replacing it with the correct one, and adding the forgotten parts.⁵ We must distinguish between deleting and correcting mistaken parts and adding forgotten parts.

This paper discusses the first type, when the scribe found extra, repeated, or incorrect words during the review and had to delete them either if they were extra or repeated parts or delete them and write the correction if they were incorrect. The scribe used the second type when he discovered that he forgot to write a sign, a word, or several words and had to add them to the text above lines or in the margin.⁶

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¹Parkinson, R. & Quirke, St., *Papyrus: écrire dans l'Égypte antique*; [translated from English by Bruno Marty], Kitab tabulae 6, Paris, 2010, 54.

²Enmarch, R., *Paratextual signs in Egyptian texts of the Old and Middle Kingdoms*. In: Carlig, Nathan, Guillaume Lescuyer, Aurore Motte, and Nathalie Sojic (eds). *Signes dans les textes: continuités et ruptures des pratiques sribales en Égypte pharaonique, gréco-romaine et byzantine. Actes du colloque international de Liège (2–4 juin 2016)*, Liège: Presses Universitaires de Liège, 2020, 46.

³Parkinson, R. & Quirke, St., *Papyrus*, 2010, 55.

⁴Enmarch, R., *Paratextual signs in Egyptian texts of the Old and Middle Kingdoms*, 2020, 46.

⁵Winand, J., *Quand le texte ne suffit plus. Éléments de réflexion sur la notion de paratexte dans l'Égypte ancienne*. In Carlig, Nathan, Guillaume Lescuyer, Aurore Motte, and Nathalie Sojic (eds). *Signes dans les textes. Continuités et ruptures des pratiques sribales en Égypte pharaonique, gréco-romaine et byzantine*, 2020, 21.

⁶I will discuss this type of correction in another paper.

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Numerous corrections were inserted in religious manuscripts, such as the Book of the Dead papyri and mummy bandages throughout the ages,⁷ indicating revisions to improve the text by the ancient Egyptian scribe.⁸ Also, there were clear indications that the text was revised and arranged, as evidenced by the colophon of the Book of the Dead papyrus of Yuya from the 18th Dynasty, preserved in the Egyptian Museum No. (CGC 51189, J.E. 95839), which mentioned, *iw.s pw m h3t.s r phwy.s(y) mi gmyt <m> sš sphr.ti shsf.ti smtr.ti smh3.t(i) ti(t) r ti(t) it-ntr Ywiz m3^c-hrw*.⁹ This means "it [the book] was completed from its beginning to its end as it was found written, copied, reviewed, compared, corrected, sign by sign, for the god's father Yuya, the justified."¹⁰

These corrections help us know why and how various mistakes were discovered. Did the scribe discover them when reviewing the text by himself or a workmate? Then, we investigate how he could add the correction without making the text appear ugly, as the ancient Egyptian texts not only give us cultural, historical, and religious information but also give us an impression and an idea about the scribes who wrote these texts. They also show the scribes' interest in and their attempts to revise, modify, and review the text until it was mistake-free.

1. Deletion and correction in religious manuscripts

The scribe used several methods to delete and correct mistakes, fewer in number than those we use today, but also accurate.¹¹ These different correction techniques depend on the material type and the size of the mistake made by the scribe,¹² which

⁷Kockelmann, H., Untersuchungen zu den späten Totenbuch Handschriften auf Mumienbinden II: Handbuch zu den Mumienbinden und Leinenamuletten, SAT 12, Wiesbaden, 2008, 137; Verhoeven, U., *Paratextual signs in Egyptian funerary and religious texts from the Saite and early Ptolemaic Period*. In: Carlig, Nathan, Guillaume Lescuyer, Aurore Motte, and Nathalie Sojic (eds). *Signes dans les textes : continuités et ruptures des pratiques sribales en Égypte pharaonique, gréco-romaine et byzantine. Actes du colloque international de Liège (2–4 juin 2016)*, Liège: Presses Universitaires de Liège, 2020, 96.

⁸Kockelmann, H., Untersuchungen zu den späten Totenbuch Handschriften auf Mumienbinden II, 2008, 137.

⁹Naville, E., Papyrus funéraires de la XXI^e dynastie II. Le Papyrus hiératique de Katseshni au musée du Caire, Paris, 1914, 19, pl. XXXIII; Lenzo Marchese, G., *Les colophons dans la littérature égyptienne*, BIFAO 104, 2004, 369.

¹⁰Černý, J., *Paper and Books in ancient Egypt*, London, 1947, 25; Allen, Th. G., *The Book of the Dead or Going Forth by Day: Ideas of the Ancient Egyptians Concerning the Hereafter as Expressed in Their Own Terms*. SAOC 37, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1974, 3.

¹¹Gasse, A., *Un Papyrus et son scribe: Le livre des Morts Vatican - Museo Gregoriano Egizio 48832*, Paris, 2002, 28.

¹²Allam, M., marking signs in Hieratic and Glosses in Ancient Egyptian Texts. *BEMC* 4, 2007, 30.

may be a sign, a word, or a group of words,¹³ as well as the time of discovering and correcting the mistake.¹⁴ If these mistakes were noticed during copying, they were corrected immediately,¹⁵ as the scribe could erase and cross out the wrong word and write the correct word immediately after that on the same line.¹⁶ However, other mistakes were identified only during review or comparison with other manuscripts. They were deleted only if they were redundant and rewritten in black or red if they were incorrect.¹⁷ It was noted that the scribe often used red ink to correct mistakes.¹⁸

In some cases, the scribe deleted incorrect words and did not write the correction, or he wrote the correction part after the mistake without deleting it; both were incomplete corrections.

1.1. Erasing incorrect signs and words, then putting the correct ones

In rare cases, the scribe discovered a mistake immediately while writing the word or after writing a group of words. Accordingly, he erased it, corrected it as much as possible, and resumed writing the correct text.

An example of this method was the Book of the Dead Papyrus of *P3-di-ḥr-p3-r* (P. Louvre N 3249) from the Ptolemaic period. The scribe removed and rewrote the incorrect part of the text before resuming writing in Chapter 42 (**fig. 1**).¹⁹



Fig. 1: Detail from Chapter 42 of P. Louvre (N 3249). Photo: Mosher, J.R. M., *Transmission of Funerary Literature*, 2017, 94, fig 7.9

The Louvre Papyrus No. (E 17110), known as Jumilhac Papyrus, contained texts related to the story of Osiris. It is difficult to determine the exact date of its texts, but it may date back to the late Ptolemaic period.²⁰ The papyrus scribe or reviewer frequently adopted this method. For example, on page 4, at the beginning of line 10,

¹³Winand, J., *Quand le texte ne suffit plus*, 2020, 21.

¹⁴Winand, J., *Quand le texte ne suffit plus*, 2020, 23.

¹⁵Ryholt, K., *Scribal Habits at the Tebtunis Temple Library. On Materiality, Formal Features, and Palaeography*: In J. Cromwell & E. Grossmann (eds.), *Scribal Repertoires in Egypt from the New Kingdom to the Early Islamic Period*, Oxford, 2018, 172.

¹⁶Černý, J., *Paper and Books*, 1947, 24; Winand, J., *Quand le texte ne suffit plus*, 2020, 23.

¹⁷Ryholt, K., *Scribal Habits at the Tebtunis Temple Library*, 2018, 172; Winand, J., *Quand le texte ne suffit plus*, 2020, 24.

¹⁸Černý, J., *Paper and Books*, 1947, 25.

¹⁹Mosher, J.R. M., *Transmission of Funerary literature: Saite through Ptolemaic periods*. In: F. Scalf & K. B. Lowry (ed.), *Book of the Dead — Becoming God in Ancient Egypt. OIM Publications 39*, Chicago, ch. 2, 2017, 95, fig 7.9.

²⁰Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, Paris, 1961, 3-4.

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the scribe erased a sign and replaced it with signs $\triangle \bigcirc$ after *šn*. Likewise, on line 9, the lower part of plate 5, the syllable $\text{𓂏} sh-ntr$ was written above an erased word. In the text above, the vignette was written above a text that was erased or removed due to a mistake.²¹

In the same papyrus plate 7, line 5, the word $\text{𓂏} dsr.t$ was written over a group of erased signs (**fig. 2**), in addition to the text in front of the vignette in the lower part, which was also written in place of erased text.²² In Plate 11, a note was inserted in the demotic script, starting from the bottom of line 16 to the bottom of line 19, but it was completely erased.²³

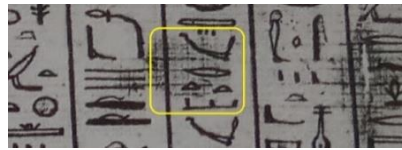


Fig. 2: Detail from the Louvre Papyrus No. (E. 17110) Plate 7, line 5. Photo:Vandier, J., Le Papyrus Jumilhac, 1961, pl. IV

Metropolitan Museum Papyrus No. 35.9.21,²⁴ which dates to the early Ptolemaic period, around 332-200 BC, the scribe erased a sign in column 36, line 6, and inserted another sign. The remains of the ink are still visible (**fig. 3**). The scribe also erased a sign and wrote another sign in the last column (62) of the papyrus at the end of line 2, and the remains of the erased sign are visible (**fig. 4**).

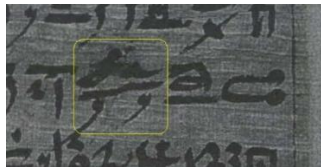


Fig. 3: Detail from column 36, line 6 of Metropolitan Papyrus 35.9.21. Photo: Goyon, J.-CL., the Papyrus of Imouthès, son of Psintaês at the Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York: (Papyrus MMA 35.9. 21). Metropolitan Museum of Art, 1999, pl. XXXIII



Fig. 4: Detail from column 62, line 2 of the same papyrus. Photo: Goyon, J.-CL., The Papyrus of Imouthès, 1999, pl. XLIII

²¹Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, 7-8, pl. IV-V.

²²Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, 9, pl. VII.

²³Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, 13, pl. XI.

²⁴This papyrus contains 62 columns of writing, forming 6 separate groups for the protection and glorification of the god Osiris. For more details and papyrus photos, see Metropolitan Museum, <<https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/551976>> accessed 28.09.2021.

In the Book of the Dead papyrus of *Tw-f-ḥnh* (P. Turin 1791), the scribe erased the wrong signs, removed the ink, and wrote the correct signs, but the remains of the erased ink are visible (**fig. 5**).



Fig. 5: Detail from papyrus of *Tw-f-ḥnh*. Photo: Totenbuchproject Bonn TM 57201, <<http://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm57201#>> accessed 3/11/2021

1.2. Changing the shape of the wrong sign to the correct sign

Sometimes, the scribe corrected the wrong sign by writing the correct sign over it or changing the shape of the wrong sign to the correct one. The scribe probably noted his mistake while copying.²⁵

An early example of this method from the 18th Dynasty was the papyrus *Hbt-nfr* I. The scribe attempted to change the pronoun from masculine to feminine in column 11, line 6 of the recto, causing a large black ink stain, and traces of his fingerprint on the surface (**fig. 6**).²⁶



Fig. 6: Detail from the recto of Papyrus *Hbt nfr* I, Column 11 line 6. Photo: Hassan, Kh., *The Book of the Dead Manuscripts of the Lady Hatnefer*, 2022, 59, Fig. 32

In Brooklyn Papyrus No. 47. 218. 50, which probably dates to the Greco-Roman period, the scribe made a mistake in the sign 𓆎 in column 16 in the middle of line 4, but corrected it immediately and wrote the sign 𓆏 above it (**fig. 7**).²⁷

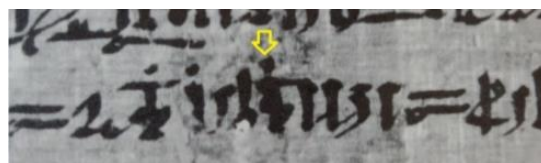


Fig. 7: Detail from Brooklyn Papyrus 47.218.50, column 16, line 4. Photo: Goyon, J.-CL., *Confirmation du pouvoir royal*, 1972-1974, pl. XI

²⁵Parkinson, R. & Quirke, St., *Papyrus*, 2010, 55.

²⁶Hassan, Kh., *The Book of the Dead Manuscripts of the Lady Hatnefer in the Egyptian Museum of Cairo: Two Hieratic Papyri and One Leather Roll* (TR-No. 25–1–55–6). *The Journal of Egyptian Archaeology*, 108(1-2), 2022, 59, Fig. 32.

²⁷Goyon, J.-CL., *Confirmation du pouvoir royal* (*Bibliothèque d'Étude*, 52, 1972; *plates: Wilbour Monographs*, 7, 1974), Cairo, 1972/74, 4, pl. XI.

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In the Book of the Dead Papyrus of *Tḥ-tȝy.s-nḥt*, the scribe corrected the signs in three places: In column 67, line 8 (C), the sign  was corrected to the sign ; in column 145, line 14, the sign  was corrected to the sign ; in column 148, line 4, the word  was corrected to  (fig. 8).²⁸

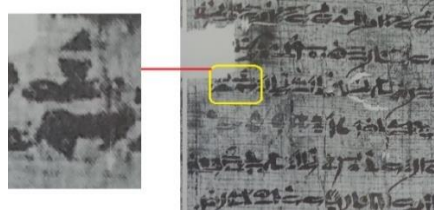


Fig. 8: Detail from Papyrus *Tḥ-tȝy.s-nḥt*, column 148, end of line 4. Photo: Verhoeven, U., *The Saitische Totenbuch*, Vol. 3, 1993, col. 148

In fragment C of the mummy bandage of *Sn-ḥtp*, the scribe changed the sign  in the word *dhn* to  in line 7, which should be  (fig. 9).²⁹ The scribe made another mistake.



Fig. 9: Detail from fragment C, line 7 of the mummy bandage of *Sn-ḥtp*. Photo: Totenbuchproject Bonn, TM 133535, <<http://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm133535#>> accessed 18/6/2022

In papyrus Vatican 48832, the scribe corrected the incorrect sign  and changed its shape to become a sun disc . In chapter 78 (column 38, end of line 5) (fig. 10) was³⁰ the only case in the papyrus for using this method.³¹

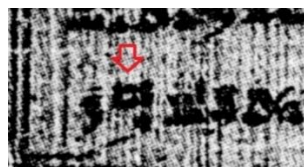


Fig. 10: Detail from Papyrus Vatican 48832, column 38, end of line 5. Photo: Gasse, A., *Les livre des Morts de Pacherientaihet*, 2001, Pl. X

1.3. Writing the correction immediately after the incorrect word

As previously mentioned, some textual mistakes noticed by scribes immediately after writing them were erased. The correct one was written. On other occasions, the

²⁸Verhoeven, U., *Das saitische Totenbuch der lahtesnacht*: P. Colon. Aeg. 10207, Vol. 1, PTA 41, 1993, 365.

²⁹Gasse, A., *L'étoffe Funéraire de Senhotep*, BIFAO 83, 1983, 193, pl. XXXIX.

³⁰Gasse, A., *Les livre des Morts de Pacherientaihet au Museo Gregoriano Egizio*, AegGreg 4, Vatican, 2001, 196 note no. a; Gasse, A., *Un Papyrus et son scribe*, 2002, 29.

³¹Gasse, A., *Un Papyrus et son scribe*, 2002, 29.

scribes changed its shape if it was a single sign. In this method, they added the correct word directly after the incorrect one without crossing it out.

The Shroud of *Tḥ-ms-ḥnwt-ṯmḥw* (J.E. 96810; S.R. 2165), which dates to the 18th Dynasty, adopted this method to correct spelling mistakes (99B), line 39.³² The scribe made a mistake in the pronoun and wrote the correct pronoun directly after it in the part  *rn.i.k*. There is slight damage in the part of the pronoun *k* (fig. 11).³³

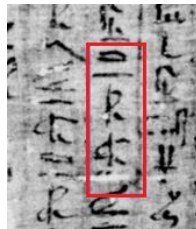


Fig. 11: Detail from fragment I of the *Tḥ-ms-ḥnwt-ṯmḥw* Papyrus, line 39. Photo: Munro, I., *Die Totenbuch-Handschriften der 18. Dynastie*, 1994, photo-pl. 1

In the Book of the Dead papyrus of *Tḥ-t3y.s-nḥt*, column 36, line 20, the scribe made a mistake in writing the personal pronoun  *i*, then immediately corrected it to  *tn* without crossing out or erasing the mistake. Thus, it became  *hr hr.i.tn*. Also, in column 30, line 15, the scribe added *n.i* after *dī.i*, so it became  *dī.i.n.i*. In column 53, at the end of line 7 and the beginning of line 8  *mdw.j mdw.n.j šms.w.f* was inserted (fig. 12).³⁴

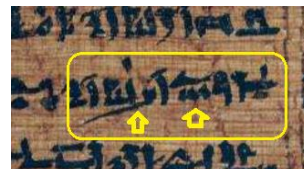
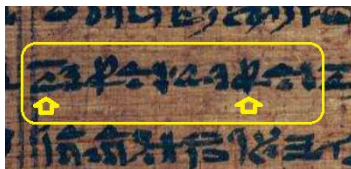


Fig. 12: Two details from papyrus (p. colon 10207), column 53, end of line 7 and beginning of line 8. Photo: Totenbuchproject Bonn, TM 57143: <http://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm57143#> accessed 17/6/2022

In the same papyrus column 17, line 6, the part *nty m ḥt* was followed by the phrase *tp ḥt*. Here, the scribe forgot *tp*, and he added it after *ḥt* and wrote *ḥt* again without deleting the first. Therefore, it became  *nty m ḥt tp ḥt* (fig. 13).

³²Munro, I., *Die Totenbuch-Handschriften der 18. Dynastie im Ägyptischen Museum Cairo*, 2 vols. *ÄgAbh* 54, Harrassowitz Verlag· Wiesbaden, 1994, 4 note. N.

³³Munro, I., *Die Totenbuch-Handschriften der 18. Dynastie*, 1994, photo-pl. 1, transcription: pl. 3.

³⁴Verhoeven, U., *Das saitisches Totenbuch*, Vol. 1, 1993, 364.

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There are many other examples in this papyrus of this type of mistake correction directly after the mistake without placing any signs or crossing out the wrong word.³⁵

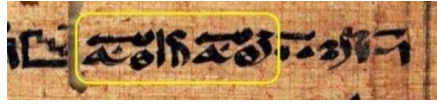


Fig. 13: Detail from column 17, beginning of line 7 of papyrus (p. colon 10207). Photo: Totenbuchproject Bonn, TM 57143: <<http://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm57143#>> accessed 6/17/2022

1.4. Striking out mistakes

Red and black horizontal diagonals were used for deletion in funerary manuscripts from early times to the Roman period.³⁶ One or two strokes could be used horizontally, vertically, or slantingly, depending on the shape of the sign(s) to be deleted.³⁷ This was the most common method, rarely using a cross.³⁸ Corrections were often made in red to appear within black text and vice versa if the deleted part was in red ink.³⁹ However, this method involved the danger of ink spreading and creating ink spots on the writing surface.⁴⁰ Also, this type of correction was sometimes considered incomplete because even if the scribe deleted the mistake, he did not put the deleted correction.⁴¹

An example of this method is the 18th Dynasty Papyrus of *H3t-nfr*. The scribe used a stroke in red ink in column 8, line 5 on the recto to delete the determinative  after *iw* without replacing it with the correct one (fig. 14).⁴²



Figure 14: Detail from papyrus *H3t-nfr* I, column 8, line 5. Photo: Hassan, Kh., *The Book of the Dead Manuscripts of the Lady Hatnefer*, 2022, 58, Fig. 26.

Papyrus of *H3.t-Hnsw* daughter of *Thi* (CGC 58006 / JE. 95845, S. R. IV 943), who was a singer of Amun in the second half of the 21st Dynasty, contained a hieratic

³⁵Verhoeven, U., *Das saitisches Totenbuch*, Vol. 1, 1993, 364.

³⁶Hassan, Kh., *The Book of the Dead Manuscripts of the Lady Hatnefer*, 2022, 58.

³⁷Motte, A., and N. Sojic, Paratextual signs in the New Kingdom medico-magical texts. In: Carlig, Nathan, Guillaume Lescuyer, Aurore Motte, and Nathalie Sojic (eds). *Signes dans les textes: continuités et ruptures des pratiques sribales en Égypte pharaonique, gréco-romaine et byzantine. Actes du colloque international de Liège (2–4 juin 2016)*, Liège: Presses Universitaires de Liège, 2020, 72.

³⁸Winand, J., *Quand le texte ne suffit plus*, 2020, 21.

³⁹Motte, A., and N. Sojic, *Paratextual signs in the New Kingdom*, 2020, 72.

⁴⁰Winand, J., *Quand le texte ne suffit plus*, 2020, 22.

⁴¹Gasse, A., *Un Papyrus et son scribe*, 2002, 29.

⁴²Hassan, Kh., *The Book of the Dead Manuscripts of the Lady Hatnefer*, 2022, 58, Fig. 26.

text of Chapter 166 of the Book of the Dead. The texts were written in black ink on recto and verso. The entire text was deleted from this papyrus⁴³; the recto containing 15 lines was completely stroked out in red ink. The verso also contained two lines written vertically relative to the lines of the recto from bottom to top, and they were stroked out in red ink (**fig. 15**).⁴⁴ Verhoeven mentioned this case: "The reason for strikethroughs remains unknown."⁴⁵



Fig. 15: Papyrus CGC 58006 (J E. 95845). Photo: Verhoeven, U., *Paratextual signs*, 2020, 98, fig. 3

In the papyrus of *G3t-sšn* (JE 95938/S. R. IV 936), from the 21st Dynasty, the scribe used red ink strokes to delete the personal pronoun $\curvearrowright k$ in plate 15, line 17, and added the corrected feminine pronoun $\text{𓆎} t$ above the line (**fig. 16**).⁴⁶

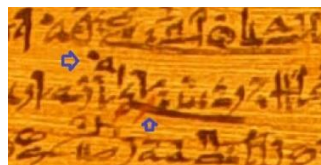


Fig. 16: Detail from the papyrus of *G3t-sšn*, plate 15, line 17: Photo: Lucarelli, R., *The Book of the Dead of Gatseshen*, 2006, pl. XV. (CD files)

⁴³Wüthrich, A., *Éléments de théologie thébaine: les chapitres supplémentaires du Livre des Morts* (Vol. 16). Harrassowitz, 2010, 181; Wüthrich, A., *Édition synoptique et traduction des chapitres supplémentaires du Livre des Morts 162 à 167. SAT 19/1-2*, Wiesbaden, 2015, 11-12.

⁴⁴Golenischeff, W., *Papyrus hiératiques*(CGC 58001-58036), Cairo, 1927, 19, pl. IV; Allam, M., *marking signs in Hieratic*, 2007, 30 with note No. 32; Verhoeven, U., *Paratextual signs*, 2020, 98.

⁴⁵Verhoeven, U., *Paratextual signs*, 2020, 98.

⁴⁶Lucarelli, R., *The Book of the Dead of Gatseshen: Ancient Egyptian Funerary Religion in the 10th Century BC. EgUit 21*, Leiden, 2006, 16, with note No. 72; Naville, E., *Papyrus funéraires*, 1914, pl. XV.

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In the fragment E of *Sn-ḥtp* Mummy Shroud, dated to the early 21st Dynasty,⁴⁷ the scribe stroked out  *hr* by using a black stroke in line 3 (chapter 84 of the Book of the Dead) (**fig. 17**).⁴⁸

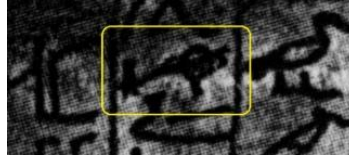


Fig. 17: Detail from fragment E, line 3 of *Sn-ḥtp* Mummy Shroud. Photo: Gasse, A., *L'étoffe Funéraire de Senhotep*, 1983, pl. XL

In Brooklyn Papyrus 47.201.84 from the early 26th Dynasty, on Delta myths, column 9, line 5, the scribe or the reviewer stroked out  *n* in red ink before the word  *b3s*, and wrote the correction  *hr* above it in red ink. He also stroked out the city determinative  after the word *b3s* in the same way. Also, in line 9, the masculine pronoun  *f* was stroked out in red ink, and the correct feminine pronoun  *s* was written above it in red ink (**fig. 18**).⁴⁹ In column 11, line 1, he also deleted the knife sign after the word *mdnw* with two strokes in red ink and corrected it to a fish sign above it in red ink (**fig. 19**).⁵⁰

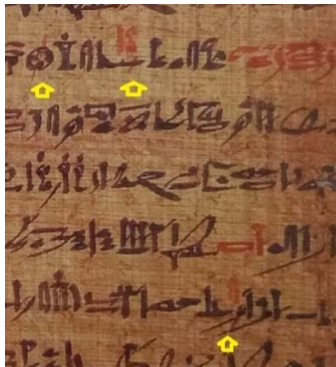


Fig. 18: Detail from Brooklyn Papyrus 47.201.84, column 9, lines 5 and 9. Photo: Meeks, D., *Mythes et Légendes du Delta*, 2006, pl. 9

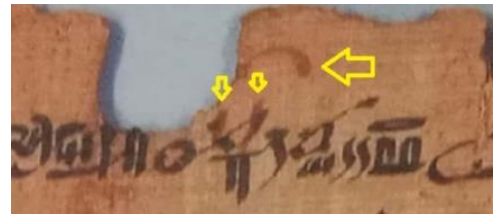


Fig. 19: Detail from Brooklyn Papyrus 47.201.84, column 11, line 1. Photo: Meeks, D., *Mythes et Légendes du Delta*, 2006, pl. 11

⁴⁷Gasse, A., *L'étoffe Funéraire de Senhotep*, 1983, 191, with note No. 1.

⁴⁸Gasse, A., *L'étoffe Funéraire de Senhotep*, 1983, 193-194, pl. XL.

⁴⁹Meeks, D., *Mythes et Légendes du Delta d'après le Papyrus Brooklyn 47. 218. 84, (Mémoires publiés par les membres de l'institut français d'archéologie orientale, 125)*, Cairo, 2006, 101, with note No. 285, pl. 9, l. 5.

⁵⁰Meeks, D., *Mythes et Légendes du Delta*, 2006, 112, with note No. 345, pl. 11.

Brooklyn Papyrus 47.208.49, from the Saite period (Dynasty 26),⁵¹ contained a few mistakes that were stroked out with red ink, such as those in column 8, line 2, where the scribe stroked out  *n.i.* Similarly, in column 10, line 10, he stroked out  *t3* (**fig. 20**).⁵²

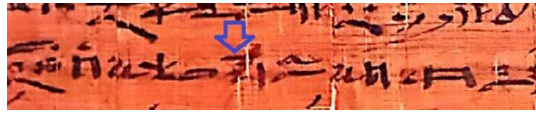


Fig. 20: Detail from Brooklyn Papyrus 47.208.49, column 10, line 10. Photo: O'RORKE (2015): pl. 10A

In Papyrus Vatican 48832, the scribe used the striking out method 6 times.⁵³ He stroked out three signs in chapter 17, column 3, end of line 7 (**fig. 21**).⁵⁴ The signs were written in mistake and should be deleted. They were stroked out at the top and bottom with a horizontal strike in black ink; but when the mistake was in one sign, as in column 7, line 5, he reduced the line to a dot at the base and top of the sign.⁵⁵

Sometimes, whole lines or only parts of a line were stroked out. Often, the stroked-out section began at the end of the line and continued at the beginning of the next line. According to Gasse, "the interpretation of these stroked-out lines is ambiguous, and we can doubt that they were actually corrections, as the stroked-out text was not replaced" (**fig. 22**).⁵⁶

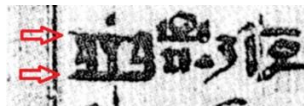


Fig. 21: Detail from Papyrus Vatican 48832, column 3, line 7. Photo: Gasse, A., *Les livre des Morts de Pacherientaihet*, 2001, pl. I



Fig. 22: Lower part of column 71 of Papyrus Vatican 48832. Photo: Gasse, A., *Les livre des Morts de Pacherientaihet*, 2001, pl. XIX

In the Bremner-Rhind Papyrus (BM EA 10188), dated to the Ptolemaic period (305 BC),⁵⁷ which recorded four different groups of religious texts intended for

⁵¹This papyrus records a text called "The Royal Book of Protection". It represents 17 texts devoted to protecting the ears of King Psmatik, one of the most famous kings in the 26th Dynasty. For more details about this papyrus, see Brooklyn Museum, <<https://www.brooklynmuseum.org/opencollection/objects/60691>> accessed 1-11-2021.

⁵²O'rourke, P., *A Royal Book of Protection of the Saite Period: P Brooklyn 47.218.49. YES*, New Haven, CT, 2015, 23, pl. 8A-10A.

⁵³Gasse, A., *Un Papyrus et son scribe*, 2002, 29.

⁵⁴Gasse, A., *Les livre des Morts de Pacherientaihet*, 2001, 30.

⁵⁵Gasse, A., *Un Papyrus et son scribe*, 2002, 29.

⁵⁶Gasse, A., *Un Papyrus et son scribe*, 2002, 33.

⁵⁷Faulkner, R.O., *The Papyrus Bremner-Rhind*, 1933, VIII; British Museum, <https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA10188-10> accessed 27.09.2021.

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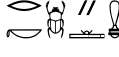
certain temple libraries,⁵⁸ the scribe stroked out the end of the word  *mi.t* with a thick vertical stroke in black ink in column 5, line 12, to become  *mi hpr.k*.⁵⁹ This correction was made by the scribe during or shortly after writing and not by examination by another person because the pen showed the same characteristics and quality as the main text (fig. 23).⁶⁰



Fig. 23: Detail from the British Museum Papyrus 10188, column 5, line 12. Photo: British Museum, <https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA10188-2> accessed 2/11-2021

Louvre Papyrus E 17110 (Jumilhac Papyrus), from Ptolemaic period,⁶¹ contained many examples of striking out, such as in Plate 2, line 18, where the scribe or reviewer stroked out signs  after  using a stroke in black ink,⁶² and he stroked out a wrong word and completely erased it in black ink after *šm*. In Plate 3, line 7, and at the end of line 10, another sign was stroked out and completely deleted (fig. 24).⁶³

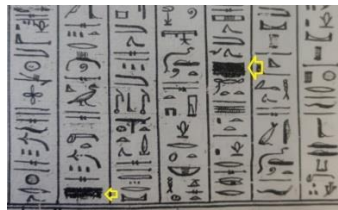


Fig. 24: Detail from Louvre Papyrus (E 17110), Plate 3, lines 7 and 10. Photo: Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, PL. III

The spelling mistakes and corrections in the Book of the Dead papyrus manuscripts were like those found on mummy bandages,⁶⁴ such as the mummy bandage of Hor (*Hr*) preserved in Berlin, fragment (3073 No. 2), which contains texts of the Book of the Dead chapter 15. The scribe stroked out the spelling mistake  *stm* in line 1 and rewrote it correctly  *sdm.i* above the line (fig. 25).⁶⁵

⁵⁸Faulkner gave names to these text groups, see: Faulkner, R.O., *The Papyrus Bremner-Rhind*, 1933, VI-VII-VIII.

⁵⁹Faulkner, R.O., *The Papyrus Bremner-Rhind*, 1933,9, note No. g.

⁶⁰Verhoeven, U., *Paratextual signs*, 2020,97-98.

⁶¹Louvre museum, <<https://collections.louvre.fr/en/ark:/53355/cl010003518>>accessed 3/2/2022.

⁶²Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, 5, PL. II.

⁶³Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, 6, PL. III.

⁶⁴Kockelmann, H., *Untersuchungen zu den späten Totenbuch Handschriften auf Mumienbinden II*, 2008, 136, with note No. 127.

⁶⁵Kockelmann, H., *Untersuchungen zu den späten Totenbuch Handschriften auf Mumienbinden II*, 2008, 137, with note No. 138; Kockelmann, H., *Untersuchungen zu den*

Similarly, on another bandage (3073 No. 5), which records texts of the Book of the Dead chapter 17, line 9, the scribe stroked out the words he repeated by mistake in the next column (**fig. 26**).⁶⁶

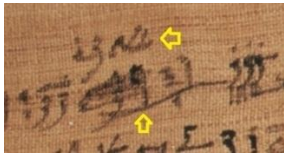


Fig. 25: Detail from the mummy bandage of Hor (p. 3073 No. 2), line 1. Photo: Totenbuchproject Bonn, TM: <<http://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm114106#>> accessed 18/6/2022



Fig. 26: Detail from the mummy bandage of Hor (p. 3073 No. 5), the last line. Photo: Totenbuchproject Bonn, TM 114106: <<http://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm114106#>> accessed 18/6/2022

1.5. Covering the mistaken part with white paint

Sometimes, the scribe adopted a new method to delete and correct mistakes by hiding and covering the mistaken part with white paint,⁶⁷ then writing the correct word(s) over it, like fragment C of *Sn-htp* shroud from the early 21st Dynasty.⁶⁸ In line 20, which records the texts of chapter 113 of the Book of the Dead, the scribe whitened out the sign  and turned it around to give the sign  (**fig. 27**). Similarly, in fragment B, at the beginning of line 1, which records the texts of chapter 124, he covered some signs which can be seen under the white layer.⁶⁹



Fig. 27: Detail from fragment C, line 20 of *Sn-htp* shroud. Photo: Totenbuchproject Bonn, TM 133535, <<http://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm133535#>> accessed 18/6/2022

1.6. A semicircular line or a dotted semicircle around the wrong word

A distinctive method of deleting wrong words in hieratic and cursive hieroglyphic manuscripts was to place a semicircular line around the wrong word to refer to it

späten Totenbuch I.1-2: *Die Mumienbinden und Leinenamulette des memphitischen Priesters Hor*. SAT 12, Wiesbaden, 2008, photo pl. 8.

⁶⁶Kockelmann, H., *Untersuchungen zu den späten Totenbuch Handschriften auf Mumienbinden II*, 2008, 137, with note No. 138; Kockelmann, H., *Untersuchungen zu den späten Totenbuch I.1-2*, 2008, photo pl. 12.

⁶⁷Dr. Khaled Hassan mentioned to me while discussing this point that this method of erasing errors is like what we do in the present time to erase errors using a corrector pen.

⁶⁸Gasse, A., *L'étoffe Funéraire de Senhotep*, 1983, 191.

⁶⁹Gasse, A., *L'étoffe Funéraire de Senhotep*, 1983, 193-194, pl. XXXIX.

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being deleted from the text. For example, in the Papyrus of *Tw.f-nh* from the Ptolemaic period (P. Turin 1791), the word  *mni* "dock" means "to die"⁷⁰ in spell 18 at the end of line 2, and the correct determinative was the mummy on the bed with this meaning. However, the scribe initially made a mistake and wrote it with the boat determinative  and then realized the mistake and wrote the correct determinative immediately after it and drew a circle in red ink around the boat determinative to indicate that it was a wrong determinative and should be deleted (**Fig. 28**).⁷¹ Here, it also represents the method of writing the correction immediately after the wrong word.



Fig. 28: Detail from Turin Papyrus 1791, spell 18. Photo: Totenbuchproject Bonn, TM 133535, <<https://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm57201#>> accessed 18/6/2022

In the Jumilhac Papyrus, the reviewer placed a semicircular line around the word  *rdw* "liquid"⁷² in plate 13, end of line 12, to indicate that it should be deleted (**fig. 29**).⁷³



Fig. 29: Detail from Jumilhac Papyrus, plate 13, line 12. Photo: Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, pl. XIII

A less common method was to enclose the wrong word with dots. For example, in the Bremner-Rhind Papyrus (BM EA 10188), the scribe circled the word  *wnm.s* "eat" in column 25, line 8 (**fig. 30**), where it was already written at the end of the previous line (**dittography**).⁷⁴

⁷⁰This word is still used today to express death.

⁷¹Verhoeven, U., *Paratextual signs*, 2020,99-100, Fig. 5.

⁷²Erman, A., & Grapow, H., *Wb II*, 1928, 469. 6.

⁷³Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, 15, pl. XIII.

⁷⁴Faulkner, R.O., *The Papyrus Bremner-Rhind*, 1933,52 note e-d; Verhoeven, U., *Paratextual signs*, 2020,99, Fig. 4.

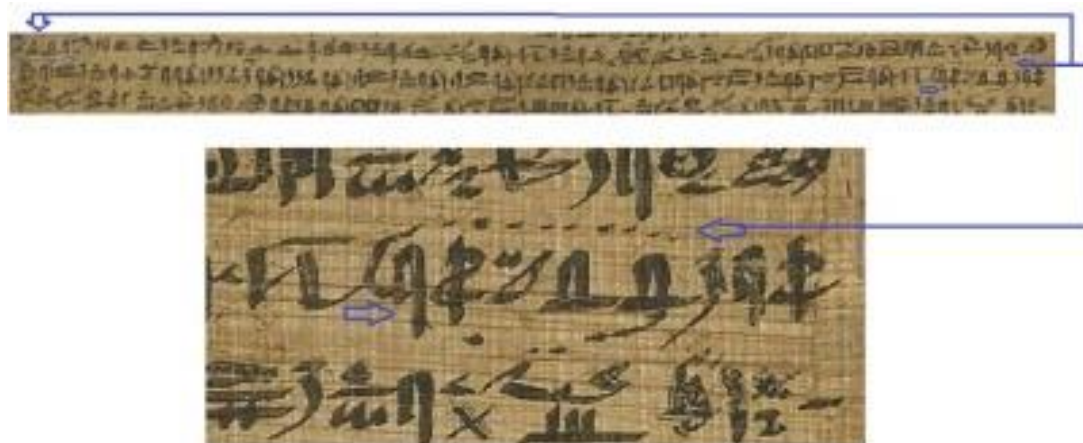


Fig. 30: Detail from Bremner-Rhind Papyrus, column 25, lines 8-9. Photo: British Museum, <https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA10188-10>accessed 27.09.2021

This method could also be found in Demotic manuscripts from the Temple of Tebtunis. For instance, in Papyrus Carlsberg No. 100, the scribe deleted the last word of the line with a dotted semicircle around the word (**fig. 31**). Also, in Demotic Papyrus P. Tebt. Tait, 4, the scribe deleted a word in line 5 similarly (**fig. 32**).⁷⁵

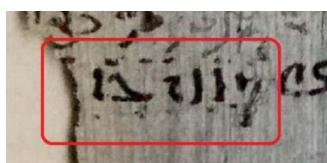
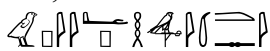


Fig. 31: Detail from Papyrus P. Carlsberg 100. Photo: Ryholt, K., *Scribal Habits at the Tebtunis Temple Library*, 2018, 173, Fig. 7.10 (e)



Fig. 32: Detail from Papyrus P. Tebt. Tait, 4. Photo: Ryholt, K., *Scribal Habits at the Tebtunis Temple Library*, 2018, 173, Fig. 7.10 (f)

1.7. Brackets around the wrong or repeated part

The use of brackets around the wrong or repeated word(s) was an important deletion method used by the reviewer⁷⁶ to indicate the deletion of the mistake. Examples of manuscripts in which this method was found in the Book of the Dead Papyrus of *Hr-nd-it.f* (P. Louvre N 3081) from the early Ptolemaic period around 300 BC,⁷⁷ which contained the oldest use of brackets for deletion. The scribe deleted  "Imstj [pw] H^cpj pw" "It is Imsti and it is Hapi", which is part of the Book of the Dead spell 18. These words were found in line 3 and were repeated in the next column. The scribe did not want to delete the names of the deities that were

⁷⁵Ryholt, K., *Scribal Habits at the Tebtunis Temple Library*, 2018, 172.

⁷⁶Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, 5.

⁷⁷Verhoeven, U., Stand und Aufgaben der Erforschung des Hieratischen und der Kursivhieroglyphe. In U. Verhoeven (ed.), *Ägyptologische „Binsen“-Weisheiten I-II, Neue Forschungen und Methoden der Hieratistik, Akten zweier Tagungen in Mainz im April 2011 und März 2013 (AAWMainz 14)*, Mainz, 2015, 32.

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repeated (**Dittography**) and was satisfied with placing brackets around the words at the bottom to indicate that they should be deleted (**fig. 33**).⁷⁸

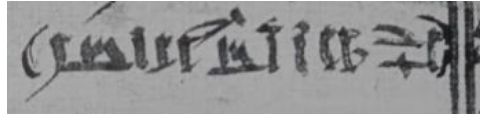


Fig. 33: Detail from Louvre Papyrus No. 3081. Photo: Cenival, J. L., *Le Livre pour Sortir le jour: "Le Livre des Morts" des anciens Egyptiens*, 1992, 54

Jumilhac Papyrus (Louvre E. 17110) contained many corrections made by the reviewer or the scribe between brackets. For example, in plate 1, line 5, the reviewer placed  between brackets to indicate that it should be deleted from the text (**fig. 34**).⁷⁹ This method was used again in the same papyrus, where the scribe mistakenly repeated the word   *shr* that appeared in plate 17 at the end of line 9 and the beginning of line 10 (**Dittography**). Therefore, the reviewer or the scribe had to delete one of them and preferred to delete the first because it was located below and deleted it by placing it between brackets,⁸⁰ as well as the plural sign that belonged to it at the beginning of line 10, which he also placed between small brackets (**fig. 35**).⁸¹



Fig. 34: Detail from Louvre Papyrus (E. 17110), Plate 1, line 5. Photo: Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, pl. I

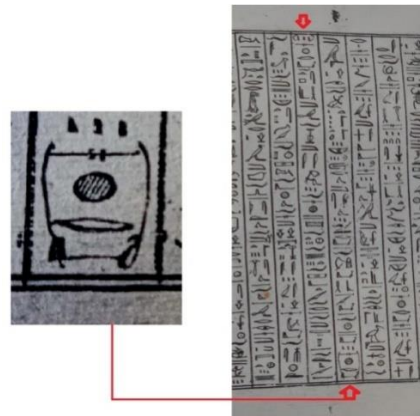


Fig. 35: Detail from Louvre Papyrus (E. 17110), Plate 17, lines 9-10. Photo: Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, pl. XVII

In the Book of the Dead papyrus of a lady called *Kk3* (P. Berlin 3003) from the early Ptolemaic period,⁸² spell 17 line 128, one bracket was probably placed in the line

⁷⁸Verhoeven, U., *Stand und Aufgaben der Erforschung des Hieratischen und der Kursivhieroglyphe*, 2015, 32; Verhoeven, U., *Paratextual signs*, 2020, 100.

⁷⁹Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, 5, pl. I.

⁸⁰Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, 199 (583), pl. XVII, Verhoeven, U., *Paratextual signs*, 2020, 101.

⁸¹Vandier, J., *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, 1961, 18, pl. XVII.

⁸²Falck, M., *Das Totenbuch der Qeqa aus der Ptolemaerzeit (pBerlin P. 3003)*, Wiesbaden, 2006, 1; *Totenbuchproject Bonn, TM 56973* <<http://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm56973#>> accessed 24/04/2021.

above the word —^ⲁⲓⲥ *hṭp.s* which was written after the name of the goddess *Hṭp.s* *hṭw.s*, but it could not be determined whether the second bracket was placed at the bottom or not (fig. 36).⁸³



**Figure 36: Detail from the Book of the Dead Papyrus of *Kk3*, Chapter 17, line 128.
Photo: Falck, M., *Das Totenbuch der Qeqa*, 2006, photo pl. 4, line 128**

2. Deletion for reuse of manuscript

Not all erasures or deletions in religious manuscripts represented corrections of mistakes as in the previous models, but a type of deletion was intended for reuse or when the scribe was forced to use an ancient papyrus written on both sides and he washed and removed the text. An old manuscript was erased from one or both sides using a damp cloth, and then the new text was written.⁸⁴ Here, the purpose of deletion was reused, not corrections. Erasure could be made on entire sheets and even entire rolls, which Egyptologists called (palimpsest), derived from the Greek word (στοσπαλίμψη) (stospalmsi) meaning "rubbed or rubbed again".⁸⁵

Sometimes, the yellow paint was used to erase the name of the manuscript owner and replace it with another, such as the British Museum Papyrus No. (EA 10478/4) dating back to the 19th-20th Dynasties of unknown origin and contained a short version of the Book of Caverns of the Duat. Although it was traditionally considered to be the Book of the Dead, Spell 168, it had a separate composition. The papyrus was prepared with great care, and the scribe then deleted the name and title of the owner by applying yellow paint everywhere the name appeared (fig. 37). Through infrared imaging technology, it was shown that it was prepared for a person called *B3k-n-Mwt*.⁸⁶

⁸³Verhoeven, U., *Paratextual signs*, 2020, 102.

⁸⁴Černý, J., *Paper and Books*, 1947, 23.

⁸⁵Parkinson, R. & Quirke, St., *Papyrus*, 2010, 55.

⁸⁶Quirke, S., *Owners of funerary papyri in the British Museum*, British Museum Occasional Paper 92. London: British Museum, 1993, 114; Lucarelli, R., *Making the Book of the Dead*. In: J. H. Taylor, *Journey through the afterlife- Ancient Egyptian Book of the Dead*, London, 2010, 279.

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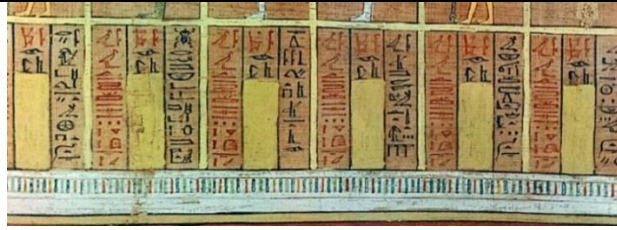


Fig. 37: Detail from British Museum Papyrus EA 10478/4. Photo: Lucarelli, R., *Making the Book of the Dead*, 2010, 281

The Book of the Dead manuscript of *Mn-n-w3h-ib-R*⁸⁷ (P. Louvre N 3091) from the Saite period, at first belonged to a person called *ʿr-ptḥ-ʿpj*,⁸⁸ but the scribe erased this name and completely removed the ink in column 1 and partially in column 2 and put the name of the new owner (**fig. 38**). However, the scribe found that it would take a lot of time and effort to do this through 165 spells and decided to strike out the name in the remaining columns until the end of the papyrus (**fig. 39**).⁸⁹ In some cases, the scribe forgot to strike out the old name, as in column 12, lines 10-11, and column 14, lines 14-16.⁹⁰

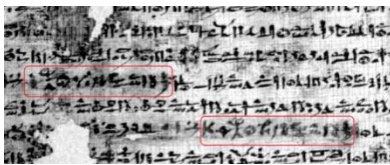


Fig. 38: Detail from Louvre Papyrus (N 3091), column 1. Photo: Verhoeven, U., *Untersuchungen zur späthieratischen Buchschrift*, 2001, pl. 3

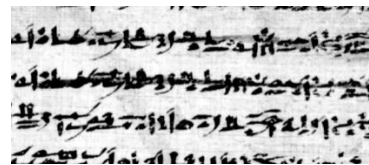


Fig. 39: Detail from Louvre Papyrus (N 3091). Photo: TotenbuchprojectBonn, TM 56602, <<http://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm56602#>> accessed 25/2/2022

At the beginning of the papyrus, column 1, line 1 from the Book of the Dead Papyrus of *T3-šrt-n-3st* from the 26th Dynasty, preserved in the von Portheim Foundation in Heidelberg (A), the name of the old owner was erased, and traces of the erased ink remained (**fig. 40**).⁹¹ The reused papyri were common until the late Ptolemaic period.⁹²

⁸⁷Kockelmann, H., *Untersuchungen zu den späten Totenbuch Handschriften auf Mumienbinden II*, 2008, 138.

⁸⁸Verhoeven, U., *Untersuchungen zur späthieratischen Buchschrift* (OLA 99), Leuven, 2001, 73.

⁸⁹Verhoeven, U., *Paratextual signs*, 2020, 99; Verhoeven, U., *Untersuchungen zur späthieratischen Buchschrift*, 2001, pl. 3.

⁹⁰Verhoeven, U., *Untersuchungen zur späthieratischen Buchschrift*, 2001, 73.

⁹¹Fuchs, K. R., *Die Totenbuch-Fragmente der von Portheim-Stiftung Heidelberg Restaurierung, naturwissenschaftliche Analysen und kulturhistorische Bewertung der Maltechnik*. In: B. Backes, I. Munro & S. Stöhr (eds), *Totenbuch-Forschungen: gesammelte*



**Fig. 40: Detail from The Book of the Dead Papyrus of T3-šrt-n-3st, column 1 Line 1.
Photo: Fuchs, K. R., Die Totenbuch-Fragmente der von Portheim-Stiftung Heidelberg
Restaurierung, 2006, 39, fig. 8**

Conclusion

The scribe sometimes stroked out the extra part if it did not require correction. However, sometimes incorrect words were removed without correction; Therefore, this correction was considered incomplete. Moreover, the mistakes and methods of correcting them in the Book of the Dead Papyri were like those found on the mummies' bandages because the content was the same, and both were written in ink and pen.

The correction method was probably related to the time of discovering the mistake. If the mistake was discovered immediately, it was easy to erase the ink and rewrite the text correctly. Sometimes, the scribe wrote the correction immediately after the mistake without deleting the mistake in order not to damage the text or create ink spots. If the mistake was in a single sign, he preferred to change its shape from wrong to correct. But if the scribe or reviewer discovered the mistake during the review, he had several solutions, especially striking out the wrong part, whether a single sign or a large part, whether it was in red or black ink, and writing the correction above the line.

Sometimes, he used white or yellow paint to cover the part that must be replaced, like the corrector pen we use. During the Ptolemaic period, brackets and a semicircle were introduced around the repeated or wrong part. Notably, all these methods resemble what we do now when we write with a pen, and mistakes occur; the same human mind invents the same solutions.

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⁹²Caminos, R. A., Some comments on the reuse of papyrus. British Museum. In: M.L. Bierbrier (ed.), *Papyrus: Structure and Usage*. *BMOP* 60, 1986, 44.

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